

Incident Alert 0029. TLP CLEAR.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU, U.S. – Operation Overload, Activity Update September 2024	19/09/2024	2

Summary

- From January to September 2024, an estimated 71,000 disinformation emails were sent to 245 newsrooms and fact-checkers, trying to waste their time or deceive them into spreading their narratives.
- Narratives touched mostly on the Paris Olympics, the Russian invasion of Ukraine, and the U.S. elections.
- The influence operation developed inauthentic content using deceptive editing or AI and impersonated Western news outlets to spread their operational content.
- The alert was sent to European government institutions, civil society organisations, and journalists.

Incident

This update report intends to cover the evolutions we observed in the outputs and techniques used by the actors behind “Operation Overload” since our report was published in June 2024.

The initial report on Operation Overload details an ongoing disinformation campaign that primarily targets fact-checkers, newsrooms, and researchers across the globe. The operation seeks to inundate its targets with false information and manipulated content, particularly narratives that support Kremlin interests, such as anti-Ukraine propaganda.

Central to the campaign is a coordinated effort involving the mass distribution of emails to fact-checkers and journalists, directing them to false news stories promoted by anonymous X (formerly Twitter) accounts, pro-Russian Telegram channels or websites. The disseminated content is varied and includes videos falsely bearing legitimate media logos, doctored images of graffiti, and fabricated social media posts, all designed to create and amplify misleading narratives.

Notably, we can now link the operation directly to Russia thanks to newly accessed information. The email campaign targeting fact-checkers and journalists has shown both consistency in operational tactics and adaptability in content focus. The volume of emails has been significantly increasing in the last three months — particularly during global events — with a distinct focus on the 2024 Paris Olympics, where the operation sought to exploit public interest and concern.

Narrative

Paris Olympics are not safe and mismanaged. Economic instability in France, anti-Ukrainian narratives, false accusations about corporate involvement in the war, spreading rumours to harm Kamala Harris, discrediting military aid to Ukraine.

Impact

Reach: A total of 245 email addresses belonging to researchers, media and fact-checking organisations have been used by the operatives, which is more than twelve times more than we had first observed back in June. Further investigations are needed to assess if some of the recipients published debunks of fake content sent by email since June.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0135.001: Smear](#) – the operation attempts to undermine public trust in France’s stability,

Objective: [T0066: Degrade Adversary](#) – the operation tries to degrade Kamala Harris and Western companies.

[T0112: Email](#) – The influence operation is reaching its target audience through email.

[T0085.003: Develop Inauthentic News Articles](#), [T0085.004: Develop Document](#), [T0086.003: Deceptively Edit Images \(Cheap Fakes\)](#), [T0088.001: Develop AI-Generated Audio \(Deepfakes\)](#) – Develop AI-generated or deceptively edited content.

[T0143.003: Impersonated Persona](#), [T0097.202: News Outlet Persona](#) – Impersonating Western news outlets.

Recommendations

- Action taken: Alert sent to European Institutions, national governments, civil society organisations and journalists to raise awareness (19/09/2024).

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Operation Overload, Russia.	See full report	Aleksandra Atanasova (Reset Tech), Amaury Lesplingart (CheckFirst), Guillaume Kuster (CheckFirst).	Video, image, text, audio.	Email, X, TG